



BOX OFFICE

REBOUND, FINALLY

Bollywood is expected to end 2023 on a high with hits like *Animal*, after a relatively quiet period of almost two years

BY PRERNA LIDHOO

► **AFTER A DULL** phase of nearly two years, it seems Bollywood got back its mojo in 2023. Multiplexes are witnessing increased footfalls as Hindi films such as *Pathaan*, *Gadar 2*, *Jawan* and *Animal*, among others, have finally succeeded in attracting audiences to theatres. “Our Q2 (July-September) was exceptional because we had two exceptional movies (*Pathaan* and *Gadar 2*) that grossed more than ₹500 crore each. There was a tailwind of *Oppenheimer*, *Barbie* and other Hol-

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With good movies in the pipeline, the momentum is expected to continue well into the New Year

lywood biggies, too,” says Ajay Bijli, Managing Director of PVR INOX.

The performance is evident in the figures. The gross collections of all movies in India has increased over four times to ₹10,541.42 crore in 2023 (as of December 13) compared to ₹2,568.5 crore in 2022, per film trade portal Sacnilk.

With Shah Rukh Khan’s *Dunki* and Prabhas’s *Salaar: Part 1 – Cease-fire* scheduled to release in the last week of December, Sriram Raghavan’s *Merry Christmas* and Siddharth Anand’s *Fighter*, Dibakar Banerjee’s *LSD 2* and Sidharth Malhotra’s *Yodha* in the next few months, the momentum is expected to continue well into the New Year. December alone, according to Sacnilk estimates, would net ₹1,000 crore in box office collections and break the record for the highest monthly earnings in Hindi movie history.

Ticket booking platform BookMyShow says that December is shaping up to be an exciting month for cinephiles as the final set of movie releases for 2023 adds to the anticipation of rising footfalls at cinemas. “With a diverse mix of films this month, audience enthusiasm and anticipation are riding high for December,” says Ashish Saksena, COO-Cinemas, BookMyShow.

According to market research firm Elara Capital, December’s performance is crucial for Q3FY24. “We expect [cinema hall] occupancy to rise to 27-28 per cent in December, and [good] performance can boost it further.” In the third quarter, Elara Capital estimates Hindi box office revenue growth of 18 per cent year-on-year. With the upcoming releases, multiplex operators expect a blockbuster quarter. “With the kind of movie flow we’re seeing now and the confidence level of the film fraternity, it’s looking positive. The content pipeline is very good, and we should be able to sustain this growth,” says Bijli. **BT**

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